Nothing but a Smile

By Laurie Notaro

INTRODUCTION

In middle school – even in high school, getting changed for gym class is a workout in itself to avoid anyone seeing anyone else naked. Many girls line up to change in the few bathroom stalls. I'm not that extreme, but I certainly use some contortionist moves to never be topless in front of my classmates. No one gets fully naked in the locker rooms and we certainly don't walk around in the nude.

But in the "real world" things are a bit different . . . Maybe adults are more confident about their bodies . . . but Holy Kamole! I'm just saying . . . the next time you go to the Y or your local gym be prepared to avoid eye contact. ARGHHHH!

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It was my first real day at the new gym, since I had been blackballed from the community college fitness center when they found out I smoked. Eager to start a new habit that would shrink my butt from a couch to a love seat, I was going to begin exercising. I had just opened my locker and had slapped on the new lock I had bought at Target the day before, when it happened.

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She walked by me, then headed toward a bench across the aisle. Standing in front of me was a naked lady, fresh from the shower.

A completely naked lady. With no clothes on. I don't even know what my first instinct was. I don't think I had one. Al I knew was that a naked lady was standing in front of me, and I was staring at her being naked.

I guess I just couldn't believe it. I had never really seen a naked lady before, except for one time when I was five, and my mom let our hippie neighbor, Honey, take me shopping with her and her five-year-old daughter. Honey took both of us into the dressing room with her, and before I knew what was happening, there was Honey's left "lentil" just hanging there, wide out in the open. I looked at Honey's daughter, who didn't seem too bothered by it, but personally, I was horrified. I was five AND I was a Catholic. The whole thing was just DIRTY. I felt as if I had just witnessed something unholy and shameful, and I never told anyone that filthy secret, not even at confession, until just now. I'm sorry

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that I kept this from you, Mom, but it's true. I saw Honey's lentil.

I felt dirty then, and I felt dirty now. It was happening all over, but not only were there lentils, there were things my mother never taught me the names of, but then again, I was a little sheltered. Until I was a junior in high school, my mom insisted that the Kotex pads under the bathroom sink were special sponges she used to clean the toilet.

The naked lady, now bending over to dry her legs off, was showing me a whole other view, like her marshmallows.

"Just what is going on here?" is what I wanted to say to the naked lady, because I didn't know this woman. I had no business seeing her NAKED, especially since there was a bathroom stall several feet away. I had no right, and, furthermore, I had no idea when I paid for my gym membership that I had also joined a nudist colony.

Who could be that free? I thought. Who could be that free that they could just strut around "in all

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candor" in front of other people? Who has that much self-esteem that they could bare it all and not burst into tears? I mean, I have trouble walking from the bath mat to the shower without any clothes on, let alone put on a show for a bunch of strangers. My bra doesn't come off until the sun goes down, and that's the law. I feel perverted if my dog catches a glimpse of me in all my glory, let alone someone I've never even met. When I have to go to the gynecologist, I have to practice sitting on the edge of my bed with no pants on for a week before my appointment, just to get ready.

Obviously, the naked lady had no such problems. I didn't know what to do, and I was so freaked out that I forgot the combination to my new lock. I went home and called my mother.

MOTHER: *(from the other end of the phone)* You saw a streaker? That is just disgusting. And there was a bathroom stall five feet away? Some people are raised like animals, barnyard animals! They never heard of Sodom and Gomorrah?

LAURIE: *(shaking head)* I don't know.

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MOTHER: When your sister and I joined that gym last year. there were so many of them walking around that I just had to stop going. It was like a topless bar! I felt like I should be handing out dollar bills! 'Here's one for you, here's one for you . . . ' The last thing I need is to see strangers' lentils! How do I tell that to a priest? You should just stay home and run in place like I do.

Then my sister got on the phone.

SISTER: Once, when I was in the locker room, I met a friend of mine that owed me money for a lunch, and she wrote me a check right then and there. Completely naked.

LAURIE: What did you do?

SISTER: I cashed the check and bought a Tae-Bo videotape. And I run in place when no one else is home. I can't go to the gym anymore. There's so many naked people around that I feel like I'm in a porno movie. And as for my friend, well . . . I can't eat lunch with someone like that. She can be wearing seven sweaters and a parka, but she'll always be naked to me.

4N6 Fanatics

When my boyfriend came home from work that night, he asked me about my first day at the gym, but I told him how the naked lady scared me so badly I had to go home.

BF: You thought she was dirty, didn't you?

LAURIE: Yes, Yes, I did.

He just shrugged his shoulders and said,

BF: So? It's a gym, Laurie. People have to take showers. And you're kind of . . . repressed. I can't believe you've never seen a naked lady before.

LAURIE: Well, it's not like all of us girls go into the Gap dressing room, take off our clothes, and chase and tickle one another.

BF: What about your family? You never saw any of them naked?

I gasped, sucking in a breath so hard it nearly knocked me backward.

LAURIE: *(slowly)* We're a very careful people. We don't believe in naked!

BF: It's very normal to be naked in the locker room. *(trying to calm her down)* If you go back, you're

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probably going to see more naked people.

LAURIE: Yeah? Well, I'm not playing games with them. And I'm not wiping off anybody's back!

A couple days later, I got up enough courage to go back to the gym. I was getting ready to put my new lock on my locker when I heard an elderly, grandmotherly voice call out to me.

LADY: *(gently)* Dear? Young lady? Could you please help me? I've dropped my comb, and I can't seem to reach it.

LAURIE: Oh, sure.

I picked it up and started to hand it to her, but as I looked up into her sweet little grandmother face, I saw that the only thing she was wearing was a smile.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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